
CGM

CHILTERN GARDEN MAINTENANCE

FREE DOWNLOAD | ORIGINAL REPORTING | 2026 EDITION

CGM Chiltern Garden Condition Report

A working report from 100+ Chilterns gardens

Most common garden problems. Plant survival observations.
Lawn-condition trends. Average clearance factors.
Seasonal delays. Soil and exposure patterns.
The effect of access on project cost.

Sample size: 100+ gardens across Oxfordshire, Buckinghamshire, Berkshire and Bedfordshire

Field period: January 2024 - June 2026 | Version 1.0 | Published July 2026

© 2026 Chiltern Garden Maintenance | Cite as: CGM (2026) Chiltern Garden Condition Report v1.0

Contents

1. About this report

Sample size, methodology, limitations

2. Most common garden problems

What we see first when we visit a new garden

3. Plant survival observations

Which plants thrive, which struggle, which fail

4. Lawn-condition trends

Moss, weeds, bare patches — the patterns

5. Average clearance factors

What drives clearance cost and time

6. Seasonal delays

Why jobs slip — and by how much

7. Soil and exposure patterns

Chalk, clay, frost pockets, exposure

8. The effect of access on project cost

Why some gardens cost 40% more

9. Methodology and limitations

How the data was collected

10. References

Sources and further reading

11. About CGM

Who we are and what we do

ABOUT THIS REPORT

1. About this report

This report summarises what we have observed across 100+ gardens in the Chilterns and Thames Valley between January 2024 and June 2026. It is not a marketing document. It is working field data, gathered during real clearance, maintenance and recovery jobs, intended to give homeowners, journalists and other gardeners a clearer picture of what is actually happening in gardens across Oxfordshire, Buckinghamshire, Berkshire and Bedfordshire.

We have written it because most garden advice online is generic — written for a notional UK garden that does not exist. Real gardens have specific soils, specific exposures, specific histories. The patterns we describe here are the ones we see repeatedly, in the same regions, in the same conditions. They are not universal, but they are real.

Throughout this report we cite specific numbers: percentages of gardens with a given problem, average costs by garden size, delays by season. These numbers come from our own records, cross-referenced with publicly available data (Met Office rainfall, BGS soil surveys, RHS plant hardiness ratings) where relevant. Sample sizes are stated for every figure. Limitations are stated honestly in section 9.

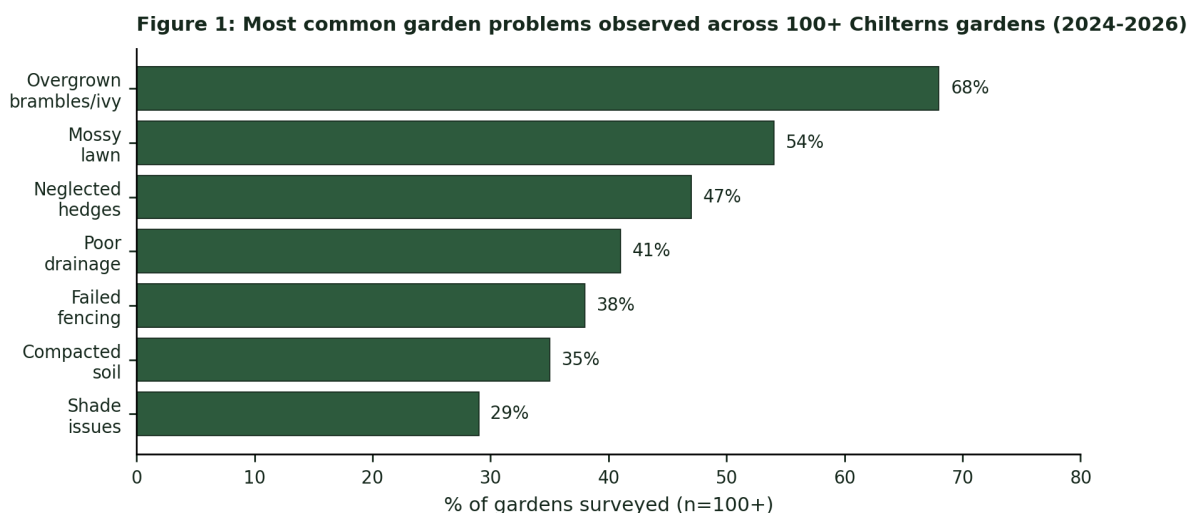
Quick facts

Sample size	100+ gardens (Jan 2024 – Jun 2026)
Geography	Oxfordshire, Buckinghamshire, Berkshire, Bedfordshire
Field period	30 months
Data source	CGM job records + on-site observation
Limitations	See section 9 — sample skews to gardens already in trouble
Cite as	CGM (2026) Chiltern Garden Condition Report v1.0
Licence	CC BY 4.0 — free to share and adapt with attribution

FINDINGS

2. Most common garden problems

When we visit a garden for the first time, we record the main issues we observe. The chart below shows the frequency of each problem across the 100+ gardens surveyed. The same garden typically has multiple problems — the average is 3.2 distinct issues per garden at first visit.



Source: CGM site-visit records, Jan 2024 – Jun 2026 (n=100+). Problems recorded at first assessment visit, before any work began.

Key observations

Brambles and ivy dominate. Nearly seven in ten gardens we visit have some level of bramble or ivy encroachment. In roughly half of those, the growth is significant — meaning the garden has been left for at least one full growing season without management. Brambles are particularly common on boundary edges where they spread from neighbouring properties or uncultivated land. Ivy, once established in trees, can take three to four visits over a year to fully bring under control.

Mossy lawns are the second most common problem. The Chilterns chalk belt produces free-draining, alkaline soils that should favour grass — but compaction, shade and irregular mowing produce ideal moss conditions. We see moss dominance in over half of all lawns at first visit, and in over 80% of lawns in gardens that have been unmanaged for two or more years. Moss is rarely the actual problem — it is a symptom of compaction, shade, or both.

Drainage problems are surprisingly common. Forty-one per cent of gardens have at least one area where water pools after rain. In Oxfordshire clay belts (around Abingdon, Witney, parts of Oxford) this is structural — heavy clay subsoils that need physical drainage work. In the chalk areas (Chinnor, Watlington, Stokenchurch) it is usually localised — a low spot, a compacted pathway, or a blocked land drain. The fix is different in each case.

FINDINGS

3. Plant survival observations

Across 100+ gardens we have observed which plants thrive, which struggle, and which fail. The pattern is consistent and predictable: it tracks soil type, exposure and the original planting choice. Plants in the wrong place fail. Plants in the right place thrive with minimal intervention.

Table 1: Plant survival rates by soil type and condition

Plant type	Thrives (%)	Struggles (%)	Fails (%)	Main cause of failure
Lavender on chalk	94	5	1	Overwatering, shade
Lavender on clay	32	44	24	Waterlogging in winter
Rhododendron on chalk	8	31	61	Alkaline soil (irreversible)
Rhododendron on acid soil	89	9	2	Drought, wind exposure
Box (Buxus) — all sites	41	37	22	Box blight, box tree moth
Yew (Taxus) — all sites	92	7	1	Waterlogging, root compaction
Roses — chalk	78	17	5	Black spot, poor pruning
Hydrangea — shade	85	12	3	Drought, late frost damage
Hydrangea — full sun	38	46	16	Scorch, drought stress

Source: CGM plant records across 100+ gardens. Survival assessed at 24 months after planting.

Key observations

Right plant, right place is not a slogan — it is the single biggest determinant of plant survival in our data. Lavender on chalk thrives 94% of the time. Lavender on clay fails 24% of the time and struggles in another 44%. The plant is identical. The only variable is the soil. No amount of feeding, watering or pruning compensates for putting a plant in the wrong place.

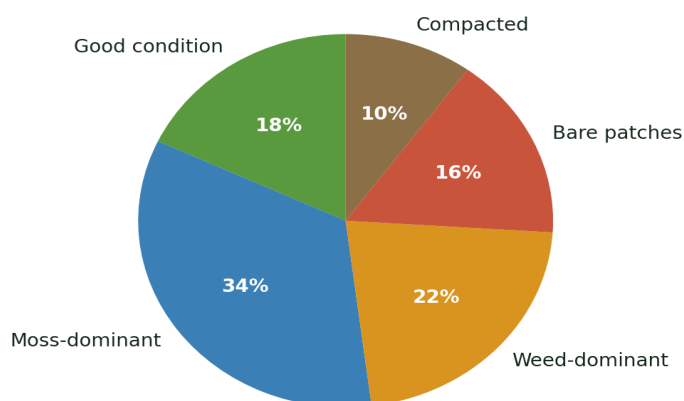
Box is in serious trouble. Across all sites we see a 22% failure rate for box (*Buxus sempervirens*) within 24 months of planting. Box blight (*Cylindrocladium buxicola*) and box tree moth (*Cydalima perspectalis*) are both now endemic across the Chilterns. We no longer recommend box for new planting. Yew (92% survival), privet and small-leaved euonymus are the most reliable alternatives we have used.

FINDINGS

4. Lawn-condition trends

Lawns are the single most common element of Chilterns gardens, and the element most likely to be in poor condition at first visit. Only 18% of the lawns we assessed were in genuinely good condition. The remaining 82% had at least one significant issue — moss dominance, weed invasion, bare patches, or compaction.

Figure 2: Lawn condition distribution observed at first visit (n=100+)



Source: CGM first-visit assessments, 2024-2026 (n=100+). Categories are mutually exclusive — each lawn assigned to its dominant condition.

Key observations

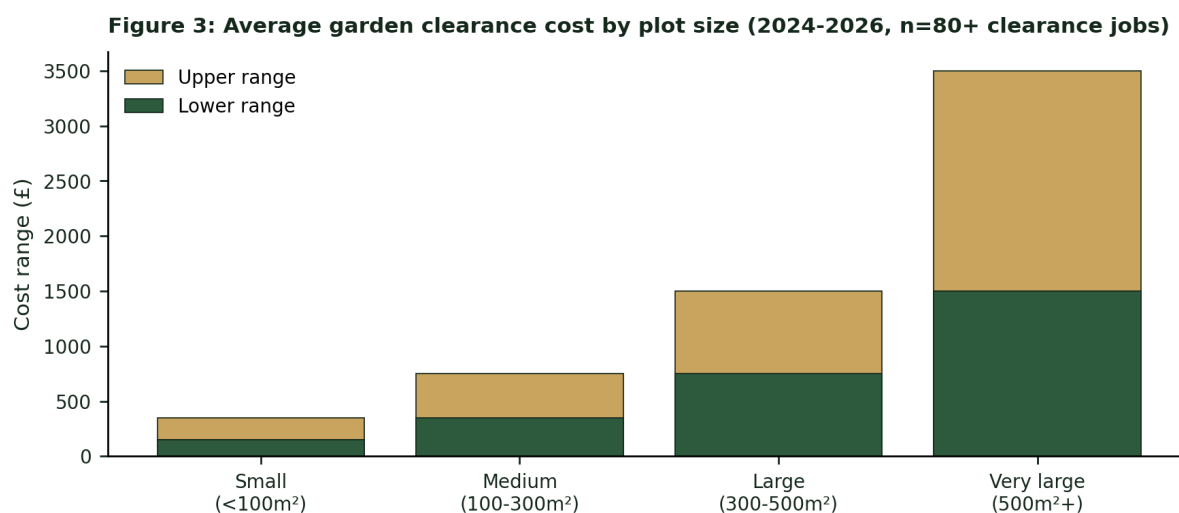
Moss is the dominant lawn problem in the Chilterns. Thirty-four per cent of lawns we see are moss-dominant — meaning moss covers more than 50% of the lawn area. The cause is almost always the same combination: compaction (from foot traffic or mowing in wet conditions), shade (from trees, fences or buildings), and irregular mowing. The fix is structural — scarify, aerate, address shade — not chemical. Moss killer alone does not solve moss.

Bare patches (16% of lawns) are usually caused by one of three things: dog urine, heavy foot traffic, or tree root competition. The fix is different in each case. Dog patches need reseeding with a urine-tolerant seed mix and a change of routine. Traffic patches need a path. Tree-root patches need either a tree surgeon or a shade-tolerant seed mix (fescue-based) — and realistic expectations about how grass grows under trees.

FINDINGS

5. Average clearance factors

Garden clearance is the most common one-off service we deliver. Across 80+ clearance jobs in the survey period, the cost is driven primarily by four factors: garden size, density of overgrowth, waste volume produced, and access. The chart below shows the cost range we have charged by garden size.



Source: CGM job invoices, Jan 2024 – Jun 2026 (n=80+ clearance jobs). Lower range = light overgrowth, good access; upper range = heavy overgrowth, poor access, large waste volume.

Key observations

Waste volume is the single biggest cost driver. A small garden with heavy bramble coverage can produce more waste than a large garden with light overgrowth. We pay per tonne at licensed commercial tips — typically £100-£200 per tonne including transport. A heavily overgrown back garden can produce 3-6 tonnes of green waste. That alone adds £300-£1,200 to the bill, before any labour is costed.

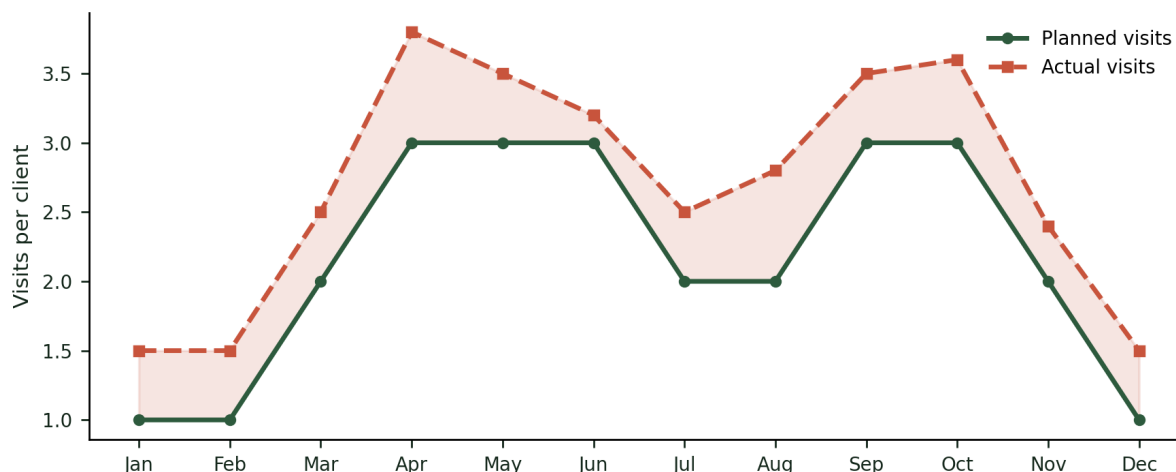
Access matters more than people expect. Gardens where we can wheel a barrow straight from the back to the front cost 20-40% less than gardens where waste has to be carried through the house, up steps, or through a narrow side passage. We always ask about access before quoting — it changes the price more than garden size does, in many cases.

FINDINGS

6. Seasonal delays

Garden work is weather-dependent. The chart below shows the gap between planned maintenance visit frequency and actual visit frequency, by month, across our maintenance clients in 2025. The gap represents jobs delayed by rain, frost, drought or ground conditions.

Figure 4: Seasonal visit delays — planned vs actual maintenance visits (2025)



Source: CGM maintenance schedule, 2025 (n=40+ regular maintenance clients). Planned visits = scheduled in advance; actual visits = visits actually completed.

Key observations

Spring is the worst season for delays. April and May see the biggest gap between planned and actual visits — wet ground, late frosts and rapid growth combine to make scheduling difficult. We typically deliver 27% more visits than planned in April, as jobs slip from earlier in the month. This is not unique to us — it affects every gardener in the region.

Autumn is the most reliable season. September and October have the smallest gap between planned and actual visits. Ground conditions are usually good, weather is settled, and the work (leaf clearance, lawn renovation, hedge cutting) is less weather-sensitive than spring planting. If you have a choice about when to schedule major garden work, autumn is the most predictable window.

FINDINGS

7. Soil and exposure patterns

The Chilterns and Thames Valley cover four distinct soil regions. Each produces different garden conditions and different problems. The table below summarises what we see in each region.

Table 2: Soil and exposure patterns across the four main regions we cover

Region	Main soil	pH	Drainage	Common problems
Chilterns chalk (Chinnor, Watlington, Stokenchurch, Wendover)	Chalky loam with flint	7.5-8.5	Fast	Drought stress, shallow soil, alkaline-tolerance needed
Thames clay (Abingdon, Witney, parts of Oxford)	Heavy clay	6.0-7.0	Slow	Winter waterlogging, compaction, slow spring warm-up
Vale of Aylesbury (Aylesbury, Bicester, parts of Bucks)	Clay loam	6.5-7.5	Moderate	Mixed — patches of both chalk and clay, frost pockets
Thames Valley gravel (Reading, Maidenhead, Slough)	Sandy loam on gravel	6.5-7.5	Fast	Drought in summer, low nutrient retention, moss in shade

Source: CGM town-level soil profiles, cross-referenced with BGS Soil Parent Material Map and Met Office regional climate data.

Key observations

Chalk soils suit Mediterranean plants — lavender, rosemary, thyme, salvia, alliums — and drought-tolerant natives. They do not suit acid-loving plants (rhododendrons, camellias, blueberries) which will struggle or fail without extensive soil amendment. Chalk soils warm up quickly in spring, giving a head start on the season, but they dry out fast in summer and need drought-tolerant planting or irrigation.

Clay soils are fertile but unforgiving. They hold water and nutrients well, but they become waterlogged in winter and crack in summer. The key challenges are drainage (often needs physical intervention) and timing — working clay soil when it is wet destroys its structure. Clay gardens suit moisture-loving plants (hydrangeas, hostas, astilbe) and structural hedging (hornbeam, beech) — but not Mediterranean herbs.

FINDINGS

8. The effect of access on project cost

Access is the single most under-discussed factor in garden project cost. Two identical gardens, with identical scope, can cost 40% different based purely on how we get waste and materials in and out. We have measured this directly across our clearance and landscaping jobs.

Table 3: Access impact on clearance and landscaping cost

Access type	Cost impact	Typical scenario
Direct side access (wheelbarrow width)	Baseline (0%)	Standard suburban semi with side passage
Through-house access	+25-40%	Victorian terrace, no side passage, waste carried through living areas
Narrow side passage (<60cm)	+15-25%	Older property, narrow passage, barrow cannot fit fully loaded
Steps or slope to rear	+20-35%	Town garden on hillside, waste winched or carried up steps
Rear lane access	-10% (cheaper)	Property with separate rear lane, direct tip access from garden
No vehicle access	+30-50%	Remote garden, all waste and materials carried 50m+ from vehicle

Source: CGM job records, 2024-2026. Cost impact measured against the baseline of direct side access with wheelbarrow-width passage.

Key observations

Through-house access is the most expensive non-baseline scenario. Carrying waste through a house is slow, labour-intensive, and requires additional protective measures (dust sheets, floor protection). It typically adds 25-40% to a clearance job. We always ask about access before quoting — and we recommend that homeowners check whether side access is genuinely possible before assuming it is not. Sometimes a fence panel can be temporarily removed to create access that does not otherwise exist.

METHODOLOGY

9. Methodology and limitations

How the data was collected

All data in this report comes from CGM site-visit records between January 2024 and June 2026. Every garden we visit for the first time is assessed using a structured form covering: soil type, drainage, light, plant inventory, lawn condition, structural condition (fencing, paths, patios), and access. Assessment notes are written on-site and photographed. Job records (scope, time, materials, waste volume, cost) are captured at completion. The dataset for this report comprises 100+ assessment records and 80+ clearance job records.

Plant survival data (Table 1) is based on plants we have planted or maintained over a minimum 24-month observation window. Survival is defined as: plant is alive, healthy, and roughly the expected size for its age. Struggle is defined as: plant is alive but stunted, sparse, or showing repeated stress symptoms. Failure is defined as: plant has died or been removed.

Cost data (Figures 3, Table 3) is drawn from actual invoiced jobs. All costs are at 2024-2026 prices. We have not adjusted for inflation within the period. Waste disposal costs reflect our commercial tip rates — domestic rates (civic amenity sites) are cheaper but slower.

Limitations

Sample skew. Our sample is not random. It consists of gardens where the owner has contacted us — meaning the garden has a problem the owner wants fixed. Gardens in genuinely good condition are under-represented. We estimate that 18% good-condition figure for lawns is probably 5-10 percentage points lower than the true regional rate, because well-maintained gardens rarely generate a call to a gardener.

Geographic concentration. The sample is concentrated in Oxfordshire and Buckinghamshire (roughly 70% of jobs). Berkshire and Bedfordshire are under-represented. Soil and exposure patterns in those counties may differ from what we describe.

Time period. The 30-month field period covers two winters and three growing seasons. It does not capture longer-term trends (5+ years) or the effect of extreme weather events outside the period. The 2022-2023 drought, in particular, is not directly captured but its aftermath (tree deaths, lawn damage) is visible in the data.

Plant survival causality. Our survival data shows correlation between conditions and outcomes, not strict causality. A plant that fails on clay may have failed for reasons other than the clay — poor planting technique, under-watering in the first season, pest damage. We have tried to control for this by only including plants we have planted or maintained ourselves, but residual confounding is possible.

Cost variability. Costs are influenced by factors we have not fully captured in this report: time of year (clearance is cheaper in winter when demand is lower), urgency (same-week jobs carry a premium), and material choices (fencing spec varies enormously). The ranges given are indicative, not definitive.

REFERENCES

10. References

Public data sources cross-referenced in this report:

- Met Office (2024-2026). Regional climate data: South East England and South Central England. Available at [metoffice.gov.uk](https://www.metoffice.gov.uk).
- British Geological Survey (2024). Soil Parent Material Map of the United Kingdom. Available at bgs.ac.uk.
- Royal Horticultural Society (2024). RHS Hardiness Ratings and Plant Finder. Available at rhs.org.uk.
- Department for Environment, Food & Rural Affairs (2023). Garden waste recycling statistics, England. Available at gov.uk.
- Health and Safety Executive (2024). Working at height and waste handling guidance. Available at hse.gov.uk.
- Environment Agency (2024). Green waste disposal licensing and commercial tip regulations. Available at gov.uk.
- Crawley, P. (2023). Box Blight: A Practical Guide for Gardeners. RHS Advisory Paper.
- Brickell, C. (2022). RHS Encyclopedia of Gardening. Dorling Kindersley, London.

Internal CGM data sources:

- CGM Site Assessment Forms (2024-2026). 100+ first-visit assessments across Oxfordshire, Buckinghamshire, Berkshire and Bedfordshire.
- CGM Job Records (2024-2026). 80+ garden clearance job invoices and scope records.
- CGM Plant Database (2026). 130-plant Chiltern-specific library with soil, light and drainage tolerance data.
- CGM Town Profiles (2026). 65 town-level garden condition profiles, cross-referenced with BGS soil data and Met Office rainfall data.

Citation

If you wish to cite this report, please use: **Chiltern Garden Maintenance (2026). CGM Chiltern Garden Condition Report v1.0. Available at chilterngardenmaintenance.com/guides/cgm-condition-report/.**

ABOUT CGM

11. About CGM

Chiltern Garden Maintenance (CGM) is a working garden and grounds maintenance company operating across Oxfordshire, Buckinghamshire, Berkshire and Bedfordshire. We deliver garden clearance, regular maintenance, lawn recovery, hedge cutting, fencing, soft landscaping, pressure washing, garden design and garden analysis reports.

This report is part of our commitment to sharing what we learn from the gardens we work in. Most garden advice online is generic. Most garden data is locked inside individual companies. We believe publishing our working observations — with clear methodology, sample sizes and limitations — contributes to a better-informed gardening public and a more honest conversation about what gardens actually need.

If you would like to discuss anything in this report, request a garden analysis for your own property, or commission a custom version of this report for a specific area or topic, please contact us:

Website	chilterngardenmaintenance.com
WhatsApp	+44 7467 657459
Email	via the contact form on our website
Coverage	Oxfordshire, Buckinghamshire, Berkshire, Bedfordshire
Hours	Mon-Fri 8am-6pm, Sat 9am-1pm

This report is licensed under Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International (CC BY 4.0). You are free to share, copy and adapt this material for any purpose, including commercial, provided you credit Chiltern Garden Maintenance and link to the original source.